This passive hegemony would work for the rest of the eighteenth century, during which time Chinese armies had to enter Tibet on five occasions.

Despite Chinese intervention, the situation in Tibet simply refused to stabilize. In 1727, civil war erupted. Eventually, one of the ministers, Pholhanas, took control of Lhasa. The seventh Dalai Lama was exiled to Kham and 2,000 Qing troops were garrisoned in Lhasa with another 1,000 men stationed in Chamdo in the Kham region. In addition, the Qing emperor decided to station two Manchu imperial ambans in Lhasa to oversee the garrison in Lhasa and also keep watch on the Tibetan leadership. The ambans would continue to be in Lhasa with varying degrees of importance till 1912.

Even though Tibet found itself substantially scaled down as a political entity, at no stage did it ever lose its identity as a separate kingdom.

Pholhanas proved to be an able administrator and slowly the Chinese ambans had no role to play in the kingdom's affairs. The seventh Dalai Lama was brought back from exile in 1735 and became the religious figurehead. In 1739, Pholhanas was given the title 'Prince of Tibet', which made him the head of the aristocratic family that would henceforth rule the kingdom. Even though unrest was building up towards the end of his reign, when Pholhanas died in 1747, his second son Gyurme Namgye succeeded him. However, unlike his father, Namgye was openly anti-Chinese and started negotiations with the Dzungar Mongols. When the amban residents in Lhasa found out, they had Namgye killed. In retaliation, Namgye's supporters killed both the ambans. In the ensuing chaos, the Dalai Lama opened the Potala Palace to all the Chinese residents in Lhasa while requesting the Qing emperor for immediate help.

As a reward for his loyalty, the Qing emperor vested in the Dalai Lama extensive temporal power. Various restrictions were then put on the rest of Tibet's nobility, which effectively ended Tibet's brief flirtation with non-religious governance and internecine struggles. Once again the Chinese withdrew, leaving the Dalai Lama in control of Tibet. In 1758, in a remarkably trouble-free succession, Jamphel Gyatso was appointed the eighth Dalai Lama.

Two major events would then occur which would directly impact the China-Tibet-India equation. The first occurred in 1772 when the Bhutanese attacked the neighbouring Cooch Behar kingdom. Warren Hastings, the Governor General of Bengal, promptly engaged the Bhutanese forces. The